

Trust Isn't Something People Earn. It's Something You Give

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Quick Bridge

Most leaders think trust is earned over time through consistent performance. But there's a better way. ****You can default to giving people trust first, then withdraw it only when specific behaviors warrant it.**** This inverts how most teams operate and changes everything about your relationships with your direct reports.

The Story

I had a direct report who would overreact to everything.

Not sometimes. Everything. You tell them about a problem, and they see it as a catastrophe. You mention a stakeholder concern, and suddenly it's a personal attack. Every piece of information came back as a crisis in their mind.

The obvious answer was to stop sharing things with them. Keep them isolated. Fewer details, fewer overreactions.

I did the opposite.

I made a point to share things with them ahead as much as possible. Before the news reached the broader team. Before it became official. I gave them the information early. Then I let them overreact while I was still there. And I got it out of their system.

It sounds backwards. But something changed.

They stopped overreacting in front of others because they had already processed it. The outburst happened where it mattered least. The people they worked with every day saw someone calm and collected. And somewhere in that process, the overreacting became less automatic.

I was giving them trust from the start. But I was managing a specific behavior. How they handled information emotionally was the issue, not whether they got it at all.

That distinction is everything.

What Most Leaders Do (and What It Costs)

Most leaders treat trust like a currency people have to earn.

You start with a neutral stance. You watch. You wait. You see if they follow through on small commitments first. Gradually, over months, you increase their responsibilities and trust level.

This is the "trust but verify" model. It feels safe because you are not surprised. People have to prove themselves first.

The cost is high.

Teams that operate this way move slower. People feel watched. They take fewer risks.

****They default to asking permission instead of showing initiative because they know they are not trusted yet.****
Responsibility feels like a burden they have to earn the right to carry, not something you are offering them.

Skip-level 1-on-1s don't work because people assume any complaint will hurt their standing. Feedback stays bottled up. By the time you realize there is a problem, it has been festering for months.

And the irony: when you eventually need to hold someone accountable, it feels like betrayal. You gave them a chance. They blew it. But they feel punished for finally being trusted.

The Shift: Trust as a Default, Not a Destination

What if you flipped it?

What if the starting position was trust? Not blind trust, and not trust in every dimension. Just a baseline assumption that people are capable and well-intentioned.

Here is what matters: ****when specific behaviors don't align with how your team needs to operate, you withdraw trust in that specific area. Not the person. The behavior.**** And you say it out loud.

That conversation sounds like this: "I trust you completely with this project. What I need to see change is how you communicate setbacks to the team before we have worked through them together." Specific. Behavioral. No verdict on who they are as a person.

Most people do not know exactly where trust has eroded. Naming the behavior gives them something to act on. Leaving it vague gives them something to ruminate on.

This is not about being naive. It is about being clear.

When I gave my direct report information early, I was saying: I trust you with this information. I trust that you can handle uncertainty. I trust that you want the team to succeed. What I was managing was the specific behavior of how they communicated that uncertainty to others. And I did that management by changing when and how they got the information.

It is different from telling them: I don't trust you because you overreact.

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How to Apply This

Start by deciding what you are actually trusting them with. You can give someone broad trust on their technical judgment while withdrawing trust on their communication with customers. You can trust their ownership of a project while withdrawing trust on their hiring decisions.

****Trust is not all-or-nothing. It is granular.**** Be explicit about what you are trusting them with. Say it out loud: I trust you to make technical decisions on this project. I trust you to own the customer relationship. Say it specifically, not just "I trust you."

When a behavior shows a trust withdrawal is needed, name the specific behavior, not the person. Do not say: I can't trust you with this. Instead, say: This situation requires a different approach than what you chose. Here is what I need to see going forward.

One attacks their judgment. The other redirects their action.

Show people they are trusted by giving them information early. Do not wait for official announcements. Do not protect them from context. Share what is coming before it is formally communicated. Share the problems you are seeing. Share what you are uncertain about.

If they overreact in private, that is processing. That is healthy. That is what trust looks like in action. You are seeing the real feeling because you gave them the trust to have it.

The Behavior That Changes

Here is what happens when you give trust and manage it this way.

People take more ownership because they are not waiting for permission that feels like it is never coming. They bring you problems earlier because you have already shown them you will not shoot the messenger. They are more honest in your 1-on-1s because they are not defending a position. They are sharing a reality.

Skip-level feedback comes to you faster. Not because people are complaining, but because they know you actually want to hear it.

And when you do need to hold someone accountable, it does not feel like betrayal. It feels like a course correction. Because the trust was real. You gave it. You are just pointing out where behavior needs to shift.

Monday Action

Identify one person on your team you have been cautious about trusting. Pick one specific area where you could give them more trust. It does not have to be their whole role. Just one piece.

Share that with them explicitly: "I want to give you more trust with X. This is important to us. I am going to start including you in earlier conversations so you have full context."

Then watch what changes.

Your Turn

When was the last time someone gave you trust before you had to earn it? How did that change how you showed up?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building a team culture where people step into trust rather than waiting for permission, consider reaching out.

jessestaffordcoaching.com

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Management, Leadership, Teamwork, Communication, Professional Development

Feature Image Prompt

"Overhead view of two people sitting across from a table in conversation, warm brand blue (#100299) background, modern office aesthetic, one person leaning forward engaged while the other speaks, professional but natural interaction"